

What else to watch: *Le Corbeau* (1943) ■ *Shadow of a Doubt* (1943) ■ *Les Biches* (1968) ■ *The Unfaithful Wife* (1969) ■ *La Rupture* (1970) ■ *Just Before Nightfall* (1971) ■ *Wedding in Blood* (1973) ■ *L'Enfer* (1994)



Claude Chabrol Director

Claude Chabrol was born in 1930 in Sargent, in rural France,

where he ran a movie club as a child. Before directing his own movies, he worked as a critic for influential magazine *Cahiers du Cinéma*. Like the other directors of the French New Wave who emerged from that magazine, Chabrol was an

admirer of Alfred Hitchcock, but he was the only one of his peers to gravitate toward the thriller, making a series of murder mysteries until his death in 2010.

Key movies

1970 *Le Boucher*
1971 *Just Before Nightfall*
1994 *L'Enfer*

Why wasn't Hélène scared? This is the dynamic that Chabrol chooses to deal with in a movie that doesn't so much resemble a woman-in-peril saga as a beauty and the beast story. Comparisons could be made with Alfred Hitchcock's *Shadow of a Doubt* (1943), in which a young girl discovers that her favorite uncle is a killer of elderly widows.

Violent purity

The second murder scene explains the movie's unusual opening credits, which depict the Cougnac grottoes in southwestern France, home to a series of paintings from

the Upper Paleolithic era. Hélène gives her class a guided tour, noting that the paintings were the first step taken by man toward civilization. "Do you know what we call desires when they lose their savage quality?" Hélène asks. "Aspirations" is her answer. The teacher seems to respect Cro-Magnon man and his violent purity, which suggests a lot about her fascination with Popaul.

The final act brings revelations and confrontations in an intense scene that shows as much about the couple's similarities as their differences. The audience is left grappling with more questions than answers. In the very last shot, Chabrol returns to a scene of the River Dordogne, with which he had started the movie. "I adore symmetry," Chabrol once said. "But I'm not for simple symmetry. Symmetry doesn't mean putting one chandelier on the right and another on the left." The credits roll, and we are left to wonder about the nature of loyalty, the desires that take the people experiencing them by surprise, and the dark mystery of what goes on between couples. ■

Hélène is drawn to Popaul and his gauche advances despite, or perhaps because of, the fact that he has been damaged by his violent past.

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Le Boucher has us always thinking. What do they know, what do they think, what do they want?

Roger Ebert

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